

Deep Dive into APA's "Behind-the-Scenes" Data and Handicapping System

Hidden Stats and "Backstage" Data in the APA API

The **APA League app's API** can expose certain player statistics and details that are not directly visible on the public member site. In your `api_dump_v2.json` (and similar data files), there are fields that amount to **"backstage" data** – extra stats and info the app fetches behind the scenes. For example, the API returns **Lifetime Stats** for players with fields like a player's **matches played**, **matches won**, **"CLA"**, **defensive shot average**, etc. ¹. The **CLA** field (Current Lifetime Average) is an internal skill metric – essentially a numeric value corresponding to the player's true average skill. In one example from the dump, a player had a CLA of 7 in both 8-ball and 9-ball, indicating a high-skilled player ². Likewise, the API provides a `defensiveShotAvg` – the average number of defensive shots the player makes per match (e.g. 1.86 in 8-ball, 2.29 in 9-ball for that player) ³. These metrics are *not* shown on the public APA site or standings pages, but they are part of the data the app uses internally (likely visible to you only because you captured the raw JSON).

In addition to lifetime summary stats, the API data can include **special achievement counts** and other "hidden" stats. For instance, the JSON structure tracks accomplishments like **8-on-the-Break**, **Break-and-Run**, **Rackless nights**, **9-on-the-Snap**, etc. (often used for patches and awards) even if the public site doesn't list them prominently ⁴. These indicate how many times a player achieved certain feats, which is typically *back-end data* used for patch awards. There are also fields like `matchCountForLastTwoYrs` (matches played in the last 2 years) and `lastPlayed` date for each player's lifetime record ⁵ – again, info mainly for internal/reference use. In short, the **JSON dump is indeed a more comprehensive dataset** than what a regular user sees on APA's website. It's pulling together all the league structure (divisions, teams, rosters) plus detailed stats and history for each player. This **"behind-the-scenes" data isn't classified or secret per se**, but it's not displayed in the normal member UI. It's accessible through the API calls – essentially *backstage pass* information that the official app uses to populate certain screens (like your personal stats page) but might not be readily visible or user-facing without digging.

However, it's important to note that while these extra stats (CLA, defensive averages, lifetime totals, etc.) are *internally available*, they **don't reveal the APA's proprietary handicap formula itself**. They are more like supporting data. For example, **CLA** is likely an internal rating or a reflection of your skill level calculation, and APA even references it in their manual: *"No player may play below their CLA (Current Lifetime Average)"*, meaning a player's handicap won't be allowed to stay below what their cumulative performance suggests ⁶. So the API gave you some insight into each player's underlying metrics (probably what APA's system uses to evaluate your skill), but it doesn't directly hand out the formula or any truly "top-secret" numbers beyond those stats. Think of it this way: your data dump is like reading the **box scores** and averages, whereas the "secret sauce" is how those numbers decide a skill level – and that algorithm isn't explicitly in the JSON.

Accessing “Top-Secret” APA Data (Skill Level Calculation)

It sounds like you're looking for the **actual handicap calculation formula or administrative data** that APA keeps under wraps – essentially the “*top secret APA data*” on how skill levels are determined. The APA's handicap system (called **The Equalizer®**) is indeed **formula-driven**, not an arbitrary decision by one person. But APA **intentionally keeps the exact formula confidential**, to prevent players from gaming the system. Even league operators get only a general understanding. The **good news** is that over the years, league members and some insiders have reverse-engineered or described the system's outlines. The **skill level (SL) formula for APA 8-ball** can be summarized (in simplified terms) as being based on your **average innings per game**, with adjustments for defensive shots and other factors ⁷ ⁸. In other words, the system looks at how many turns (innings) it takes for you to win games (or how you perform in losses), and the fewer innings you need, the higher your skill level. **Defensive shots** come into play by *subtracting* those innings from the total – since a marked defensive shot indicates a deliberate safety play, it shouldn't count as a “turn” that makes you look worse. As one player explains, “*Innings minus defensive shots*” is the key metric; if scorekeepers don't mark safeties, it will appear you took more innings and thus could keep your skill lower ⁸. This is why APA harps on properly marking defensive shots – it directly impacts handicaps.

APA's official literature confirms that **wins and losses alone are not what determine skill** – it's the **performance data on the scoresheet** that matters ⁹ ⁸. In fact, you can **lose a match but still go up** in skill level if you played extremely well (e.g. a close match with very few innings) – conversely, you might win but not go up if it took many innings or the opponent was much lower skill. The **APA Team Manual** mentions that the League Operator regularly reviews and updates skill levels using “*previous information recorded on your weekly scoresheet*”, and it notes that several good scores (best performances) are weighted more to lend stability ¹⁰ ¹¹. Typically, APA uses a player's **best 10 of their last 20 match scores** to calculate the current SL ¹² – this prevents one bad night from dragging you down or one great night from immediately bumping you up too far. It's a rolling evaluation of consistency.

So what exactly is the “**top secret**” formula? While APA won't publish it, the community consensus (and leaked info) indicates it's fairly **complex but systematic**. For 8-ball, a commonly cited model is: *calculate the average innings per winning game (with safeties removed), then map that to a skill level range*. For example, **Skill Level 7** corresponds to an average of about **2 innings per game or less**, SL6 might be ~2–3 innings, SL5 around 3–4 innings, and so on, down to SL2 which can be 7+ innings ¹³. These ranges have been documented by players and even appear in Dr. Dave's analysis of the APA Equalizer system. To prevent *sandbagging* (intentionally inflating your innings to stay low), APA also employs an “**applied score**” mechanism. If a player with a high win percentage tries to pad their innings, the system will override that raw score with an *applied* innings value based on their win % ¹⁴ ¹⁵. In simpler terms, if you keep winning a lot, the algorithm assumes you should be playing at a higher skill and won't let a few drawn-out games fool it. An insider explanation notes: “*The APA system will give you an ‘applied score’ based on your winning percentage... it's next to impossible to drop a skill level while maintaining above a 50% win rate*” ¹⁴ ¹⁶. For instance, a player winning 90% of their matches will have an automatic performance floor (the system might treat their match as if it were done in a very low number of innings, no matter how many innings they actually took) ¹⁷ ¹⁸. This ensures frequent winners don't stay at a lower SL just by dragging games out. Conversely, if you lose often, the system uses your actual performance (no “help” from applied scores), so you can drop if your game warrants it. The **end result** is a handicap that reflects your true ability as closely as possible, using a combination of **mathematical averaging and business rules** (like the applied score and “best 10 of 20” rule). It's definitely not a manual or whimsical process – APA's computer software does the heavy lifting based on the data input.

From an **administrative data** standpoint, APA does have layers of review on handicaps. The League Operator (LO) in each area monitors for accuracy and fairness. The manual even suggests having a **Handicap Advisory Committee (HAC)** to watch for sandbagging or abnormal changes ¹⁹. And if a player's calculated skill (their CLA) seems too high or low due to exceptional circumstances, the LO can **appeal to the APA Handicap Review Committee (HRC)** for an adjustment ⁶. These are internal governance steps – again, not publicly visible – to maintain the integrity of the system. None of this info is exposed via the member API or normal site, but it's how APA “decisions” on handicaps are made. So, in summary: **yes, there is a formula (with multiple factors like innings, defensive shots, win %, recent trends)** for how players level up or down. It's not a simple one-line formula you can query from the API, and APA keeps it proprietary. What you *can* see (and you have, through your data dump) are the inputs and outputs of that formula – the number of innings, defensive shot counts, win/loss records, and the resulting skill levels and CLAs. The actual computational logic stays on APA's side of the wall (their servers/software). There isn't a magic “conspiracy data” file with the formula – it's baked into their code.

League Operator Accounts and Different Access Levels

You also asked whether **League Operator or Franchisee accounts see a different APA structure**, and if so, how you could view that. The answer is **yes – League Operators have an administrative interface and data access** that regular members do not. In the current APA system, a League Operator can manage divisions, input scores, and adjust player info using either a special online portal or the admin mode of the software. For example, when weekly play scoresheets are turned in (or submitted via the app), the LO uses a tool (the old system was a program called **ARES/APA Scorekeeper**, and now possibly an admin panel in the new app) to enter the scores – including innings and safeties – for each match. The **LO's interface** will show all the granular data (every player's scoresheet details, points, innings, etc.) and then compute the updates. It's essentially the **back-end dashboard** for league management. As a player, you **cannot normally see the full scoresheet or those inning details after submission** (the app only shows you a summary) ²⁰ ²¹. This is by design – APA sends the detailed data to their national system, calculates ratings, and only returns the outcomes (updated handicaps, points, etc.) for members to see. An LO, however, *can* pull up past scoresheets, match details, and even reports of players' performance metrics that players don't have direct access to.

For instance, some LO-level reports might show a player's **average innings per match, their defensive shot count, or even a list of their best scores**. LOs also see indicators if a player is “on the bubble” of moving up or has a red flag for sandbagging. The data *you* obtained via the API is likely the most you can get as a standard member login. To get the true “admin view,” you would need credentials with LO privileges. It's not just a different JSON file or a hidden URL – it's a permission level on APA's systems. The **structure of the data might be the same** (since the app is pulling from the same database), but certain queries or endpoints will simply refuse data if you're not authorized. For example, there may be administrative endpoints for roster moves, manual skill adjustments, or finance and membership info that are completely inaccessible without an LO login. Scraping with a different member's account won't help unless that member *is* an LO or has higher permissions. Even a team captain or division rep login is essentially the same as a normal member in terms of data access (the APA app doesn't distinguish those roles for data visibility, aside from maybe allowing a captain to score matches).

In practice, the only way you'd “see” the LO view is if you became a League Operator (or convinced one to let you peek). APA is a franchised business, and LOs use either a dedicated **League Management website** or the **APA League Operator application** to run things. For example, APA's manual notes that “*Local League*

Management reviews, calculates and updates players' skill levels on a regular basis" ²² – they have tools to do so that members can't use. There is also mention of LO-only committees and appeals (HRC) for handicaps, which are all internal processes ²³ . From a technical standpoint, if you're tinkering with the **GraphQL API** in the new app, you might notice certain query fields or mutations that only work for admins. Without the appropriate credentials or tokens, those won't return data. In short, **there is no known workaround to scrape the truly restricted data** – APA's system is designed with access control. Your member (or even another regular member's) credentials will only ever fetch member-level data. Using a different ID (like you mentioned "Beaver ID" – not sure what that refers to) won't grant elevated access unless that ID is tied to an admin role.

Bottom line: League Operators and APA corporate have more data at their fingertips – every inning of every match, manual override capabilities, full player history, etc. – but as an outside user you can't retrieve those through the public-facing API endpoints. The APA is pretty careful about separating what members can see versus what admins can see. While your data dump was very informative "backstage" data, it was still within the scope of member-accessible info (just aggregated in one place). The **really "top-secret" stuff** (like the exact handicap algorithms, or any disciplinary notes, etc.) lives behind privileged accounts and internal software.

To get that kind of information, the **only legitimate path** is through APA channels: e.g. become a scorekeeper or division rep (you'll see more of how innings/defenses work), or become a League Operator (which is obviously a major step). Some enthusiasts have pieced together the puzzle by recording their match stats and **collaborating on forums** (you might find threads on Reddit or billiards forums where people share their findings on how the SL is calculated – much of which we discussed above). But as far as *scraping* it directly – if it's not in the JSON you already have, it's likely not obtainable without breaching the system's security, which we **don't recommend**.

In summary, **LOs do have a different interface and additional data**, but it's not publicly accessible. Your API dump contains a lot of the "hidden" member stats (lifetime averages, etc.), which is like backstage data for each player. It's not classified info, but it's more than the site frontend shows. Truly secret APA data – like the exact formula or admin-only controls – aren't sitting in an endpoint you can hit without proper authorization. APA's handicap system is algorithm-driven and monitored by officials; we can understand it conceptually (as we did above) but we can't directly pull the proprietary code or see admin dashboards unless we're on the inside. So, unfortunately, there isn't a clever trick with a different login that will yield dramatically more info than you already got – **short of having league operator-level access**, which comes with the territory of running a league (and a franchise agreement with APA!).

That said, you've done well to gather the *backstage* stats that you did. Using those, plus community knowledge about the handicap system, you're pretty equipped to understand "what's behind the scenes." It's just that the **"top secret" formula isn't explicitly written in the data** – it has to be inferred from those stats. APA intentionally keeps it that way to preserve competitive integrity. Keep an eye on player forums and discussions; that's where most of the remaining mysteries (if any) get unraveled by collective observation and data-sharing. Good luck, and may your new understanding of the system help (but remember to *win at the table, not from the chair*, as APA says)! ²⁴ ²⁵ *(These references emphasize playing fair and not gaming the handicap system.)*

1 2 3 4 5 **api_dump APA League Data JSON Structure Analysis.pdf**

<file:///file-WRJj4esYRCLp3fLK5Tamnz>

6 19 22 23 25 **team-manual-english.pdf**

<file:///file-P6Jh3NDJcwzk6ppdRG3PdQ>

7 8 9 12 20 21 **Can someone explain the skill levels in APA? : r/billiards**

https://www.reddit.com/r/billiards/comments/12cuj4p/can_someone_explain_the_skill_levels_in_ap/

10 11 24 **How Your Handicap is Calculated.PDF**

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13 14 15 16 17 18 **APA Equalizer Handicapping System - Dr. Dave Pool Info**

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